Here, the astringent bite of green chiles and ginger is tempered by the subtlety of herbs and delicate spinach leaves. Add a dollop of cream just before serving.

spicy spinach soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 12 MINS PLUS 90 MINS MARINATING **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 2 MONTHS BEFORE CUMIN SEEDS ARE ADDED

for the chicken
2 garlic cloves, finely chopped
1¼in (3cm) piece of ginger, finely chopped
¾ tsp garam masala
juice of 2 limes
3 tbsp Greek-style yogurt
salt to season
2 boneless chicken thighs, without skin
1 tsp vegetable oil

for the soup
3 tbsp vegetable oil
1 onion, finely chopped
2 green chiles, seeded and finely chopped
1 garlic clove, finely chopped
2 tbsp ground almonds
1 quart (1 liter) hot chicken stock
1¼in (3cm) piece of ginger, peeled
1lb (2oz 500g) baby spinach leaves
large handful cilantro
handful mint leaves
1 tsp sugar
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 tsp roasted and ground cumin seeds, to garnish

1 Mix the garlic, ginger, and garam masala with the lime juice, yogurt, and salt. Add the chicken and coat. After 1–2 hours, heat the vegetable oil in a pan. Drain any excess yogurt off the chicken, drizzle with vegetable oil, and cook for 5–7 minutes on each side. Cool, then cut into small pieces. Pour any cooking juices over the chicken and set aside.

2 Heat the oil in a large saucepan over low heat. Add the onions, chiles, and garlic and cover. Cook for about 10 minutes, stirring occasionally. Add the ground almonds and cook for another minute, stirring. Add the chicken stock and ginger. Season well and simmer for 10 minutes.

3 Bring to a boil and add the spinach. When it wilts, add the herbs and sugar. Turn the heat off and remove the ginger. Blend until smooth. Pour the soup into a clean pan. Add the chicken and reheat gently. Check the seasoning and serve sprinkled with roasted ground cumin seeds.